



Hotel frontline service employees' creativity and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors: The effects of role stress and proactive personality

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ABSTRACT

The current study examined the relationships among role stress, proactive personality, employee creativity, and customer-oriented boundary spanning behaviors (COBSBs) for frontline service employees (FSEs). This study collected data from 382 FSEs in international hotels in Taiwan to test the research model. The empirical results revealed that employee creativity was positively affected by proactive personality but negatively affected by role conflict and role ambiguity. FSEs' creativity positively affects COBSBs, including external representation, internal influence, and service delivery. Internal influence also positively affects service delivery and mediates the relationship between FSEs' creativity and service delivery.

1. Introduction

Creativity, which involves the generation of useful and novel ideas for the birth of new products and services (Akgunduz, Alkan, & Gö). The hospitality industry is a customer-oriented service industry involving frequent interactions between customers and frontline service employees (FSEs). FSEs, by dealing with customers' requirements and collecting first-hand information of customer service, are in an optimal position to generate creative ideas to improve the customer service offered (Ruiz-Palomino & Zoghbi-Manrique-de-Lara, 2020; Wang, Wen, Pasamehmetoğlu, & Guchait, 2021). The crucial role of FSEs' creativity in hotel service has been recognized by researchers and practitioners (e.g. Wang, Wen, Pasamehmetoğlu, & Guchait, 2021).

With increasing competition, FSEs' creativity becomes a source of competitive advantages because using creative ideas can rapidly solve customers' problems, delight customers and then to enhance service quality and customer satisfaction. Here is a story of how two FSEs, work at Dove Mountain Resort, use creative ideas to solve customers' problem as follows (Solomon, 2017). While a guest family packed up to leave for an airport, they found that their son lost his favorite Thomas toy. Without the permission from management, the two FSEs purchased a Thomas toy and composed a tale about how a Thomas toy extended vacation, including adorable pictures of Thomas exploring Dove

Mountain Resort. And then the gift of Thomas toy with the note arrived by FedEx at the guest family.

FSEs are viewed as boundary-spanning workers with responsibilities to both internal (managers and co-workers) and external (customers) entities (Agnihotri, Rapp, Andzulis, & Gabler, 2014). FSEs' creativity may provide excellence service delivery to enhance customer satisfaction, increase impressions toward the company, and internally share their creative ideas with co-workers (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Chang & Teng, 2017; Kim, Hon, & Lee, 2010). In view to this, FSEs' creativity may simultaneously provide benefits to customers, co-workers, and managers.

Previous research on employees' behavior role behavior at the FSEs' level includes in-role and extra-role behavior. Especially, extra-role behavior is also viewed as organizational citizenship behavior (OCB) (Scheepers & Van der Borgh, 2020). The hospitality literature has discussed various OCBs, but the OCBs are not simultaneously directed to the organization, co-workers, and customers. For example, traditional OCBs are directed to the organization itself (e.g. Kim, McGinley, Choi, & Agmapisarn, 2020), interpersonal citizenship behaviors are directed to the co-worker itself (e.g. Khelifat, Chen, Ayoun, & Eyoum, 2021), customer-oriented citizenship behaviors (e.g. Garba, Babalolab, & Guo, 2018) or service-oriented citizenship behaviors (e.g. Kloutsiniotis & Mihail, 2020) are directed to the customer itself. Due to the FSEs' role of

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